

56.2 MODAL VERB FORMATIONS

Modal verbs share certain characteristics. They don't change form to match the subject, and they are always followed by a main verb in its base form. Their question and negative forms are made without "do."

SUBJECT	MODAL VERB	BASE FORM	REST OF SENTENCE
I / You / He / She / It / We / They	can	play	the piano quite well.

The modal verb stays the same for any subject.

The main verb stays in its base form.

Negatives are formed by adding "not" between the modal verb and main verb.

You **should** run a marathon.



You **should not** run a marathon.



Questions are usually formed by swapping the subject and the modal verb.

They **should** visit the castle.



Should they visit the castle?



"Ought to" and "have to" are exceptions because they use "to" before the base form. "Ought to" is a more formal way of saying "should," and "have to" means "must." They both act like normal verbs.

You { **ought to**
have to } learn how to drive.

